

MATCHA

Brilliantly colored and packed with antioxidants, Matcha is growing in popularity worldwide. This green tea, which has been around for over 1,000 years, is being touted as the “espresso of the tea world” for its strong, bold flavors and ability to perk you up.

THE WONDER DRINK

Matcha powder is a throwback to the Tang dynasty of China, when powdered tea was the norm. It was introduced to Japan by Buddhist monks who visited China and brought it back with them. It eventually became an integral part of the Japanese tea culture, being used in the Chanoyu tea ceremony. The best quality tea plants, destined to become Matcha are grown in the Uji region of Japan.

Matcha's distinctive electric green color is a result of artificial shading for several weeks just before harvest, which stimulates the production of chlorophyll. The leaves are then plucked, steamed, and dried, and the stems and veins are removed. These leaves, known as “tencha,” are then placed in a Matcha grinder and milled to a fine powder between the grinder's two granite plates. It can take up to one hour to grind 1oz (30g) of Matcha.

Matcha has high caffeine levels and is packed with greater health-giving properties than regular green teas, as the whole leaf is consumed. It contains a number of antioxidants, including EGCG, which is known for its cancer-fighting properties, and L-theanine, which helps to calm the mind and improve memory and concentration.

There are two ceremonial grades of Matcha available: Usucha (thin) and Koicha (thick), as well as a lower grade, known as confectioner's grade. Usucha is the most widely available grade and is best used for everyday consumption. Koicha is mostly reserved for use in the formal Chanoyu ceremony. Confectioner's grade Matcha is the lowest quality grade and is much cheaper to buy, making it ideal for culinary use in macarons, cake, and ice cream.



MATCHA'S GREEN GOODNESS

As the whole leaf is consumed, the nutritional benefits of Matcha are far higher than that of other teas. Matcha helps to detox the body, improves the immune system, and boosts energy and metabolism.